



ENGLISH GRAMMAR

Reduced Relative Clauses

A Complete Guide for Intermediate Learners

What is it?

Types

Rules

Examples

Quizzes



WHAT WE WILL COVER

01

What is Reduction?

Simplifying relative clauses

02

Active Reduction

Using present & past participles

03

Passive Reduction

Dropping 'which/that was'

04

Rules & Structures

When and how to reduce

05

Common Mistakes

Errors to watch out for

06

Practice Quizzes

Test your understanding

01 | WHAT IS REDUCTION?



Reduction is the process of simplifying a relative clause by removing the relative pronoun (who, which, that) and the auxiliary verb, creating a shorter, more natural phrase.

FULL CLAUSE → REDUCED CLAUSE

The man who is standing by the door is my teacher.



The man standing by the door is my teacher.

The book which was written by Tolstoy is amazing.



The book written by Tolstoy is amazing.

02 | TYPES OF REDUCED RELATIVE CLAUSES

ACTIVE

Use Present Participle (-ing)

who/that + is/are/was/were
→ -ing

- ✓ The girl who is singing =
The girl singing
- ✓ The dog that is barking =
The dog barking

PASSIVE

Use Past Participle (V3)

which/that + is/was/were + V3
→ V3

- ✓ The car that was stolen =
The car stolen
- ✓ Letters which are written
= Letters written

WITH TO

Use Infinitive (to + V)

who/which + modal verb →
to + V

- ✓ A house that you can
rent = A house to rent
- ✓ The first person who
arrived = The first person to
arrive

03 | ACTIVE REDUCTION: Present Participle (-ing)

NOUN + who/that + is/are/was/were + V-ing → NOUN + V-ing

STEP	FULL RELATIVE CLAUSE	REDUCED FORM
1	The woman who is cooking dinner is my mom.	The woman cooking dinner is my mom.
2	Students who are studying hard will succeed.	Students studying hard will succeed.
3	The child who was crying needed help.	The child crying needed help.
4	People who are waiting outside look cold.	People waiting outside look cold.

04 | PASSIVE REDUCTION: Past Participle (V3)

NOUN + which/that + was/were + V3 → NOUN + V3

STEP	FULL RELATIVE CLAUSE	REDUCED FORM
1	The car that was stolen was found yesterday.	The car stolen was found yesterday.
2	The bridge which was built in 1900 still stands.	The bridge built in 1900 still stands.
3	Food that was prepared by chefs tastes better.	Food prepared by chefs tastes better.
4	Letters which were written in ink faded.	Letters written in ink faded.

05 | INFINITIVE REDUCTION: to + Verb

NOUN + who/which + modal verb → NOUN + to + V (base form)

WHEN TO USE INFINITIVE REDUCTION:



Ordinal numbers (first, last, only)

She was the first student who passed → the first student to pass.



Modal verbs (can, should, must)

I need someone who can help me → someone to help me.



Superlatives (best, worst, most...)

He is the best player who has ever played → the best player to have played.

06 | RULES & CONDITIONS FOR REDUCTION

CAN REDUCE



Relative clause modifies the SUBJECT of the sentence.



The relative pronoun is the SUBJECT of its own clause.



There is BE + V-ing or BE + V3 in the relative clause.

CANNOT REDUCE



The relative pronoun is the OBJECT of its clause.



The relative clause uses a simple tense (no BE).



Relative clause modifies the OBJECT of the main clause (generally).



KEY RULE: Reduction is only possible when the relative pronoun is the SUBJECT of the relative clause.

07 | STRUCTURE AT A GLANCE

ACTIVE (present)

who/that + is/are

→ Remove

Keep V-ing

*The boy running away
is my neighbor.*

PASSIVE

which/that + was/were

→ Remove

Keep V3 (past part.)

*The window broken
by Tom was fixed.*

INFINITIVE

who/which + modal

→ Remove

Use to + base verb

*She needs someone
to help her.*



08 | COMMON MISTAKES

✗ The book which I read was great. → ✗ The book reading was great.

✓ ✓ The book I read was great. (relative pronoun is OBJECT — cannot use -ing)

Tip: The relative pronoun is the object here. Only omit the pronoun, don't add -ing.

✗ The man who seems tired. → ✗ The man seeming tired.

✓ ✓ You CANNOT reduce this. 'Seems' is a simple tense, not BE + V-ing.

Tip: Reduction requires an auxiliary verb (is/was/were) in the relative clause.

✗ She is the student who studying hardest. → ✗ (forgot to remove 'who')

✓ ✓ She is the student studying hardest. (remove 'who', keep V-ing)

Tip: Always remove the relative pronoun AND the auxiliary verb completely.

09 | SUMMARY TABLE

TYPE	ORIGINAL	HOW TO REDUCE	RESULT
Active (ongoing)	who + is/are/was/were + V-ing	Remove relative pronoun + BE	+ V-ing
Passive	which/that + was/were + V3	Remove relative pronoun + BE	+ V3
Infinitive	who/which + modal verb + V	Remove relative pronoun + modal	+ to + V

Remember: The relative clause must have the relative pronoun as its SUBJECT for reduction to be possible.



QUIZ 1 | What type of reduction is it?

Identify each reduced clause as Active (-ing), Passive (V3), or Infinitive (to+V).

1. The packages delivered this morning are on the table. Type: _____

2. The girl sitting next to me is from Turkey. Type: _____

3. She was the last person to leave the building. Type: _____

4. The documents signed by the manager are ready. Type: _____

5. Children playing in the park seem very happy. Type: _____

QUIZ 1 | ANSWERS

1. The packages delivered...

PASSIVE (V3)

'delivered' is past participle; 'which were delivered' was reduced.

2. The girl sitting next to me...

ACTIVE (-ing)

'sitting' is present participle; 'who was sitting' was reduced.

3. The last person to leave...

INFINITIVE

Used after ordinal 'last'; 'who left' → 'to leave'.

4. The documents signed by...

PASSIVE (V3)

'signed' is past participle; 'which were signed' was reduced.

5. Children playing in the park...

ACTIVE (-ing)

'playing' is present participle; 'who are playing' was reduced.



QUIZ 2 | Reduce the Clause

Rewrite each sentence by reducing the relative clause.

1. The woman who is reading the newspaper is a journalist.
2. The laptop that was repaired by the technician works perfectly.
3. He is the best athlete who has ever competed in this tournament.
4. The children who were playing in the garden are my cousins.
5. This is the only restaurant that can satisfy my taste.

QUIZ 2 | ANSWERS

The woman reading the newspaper is a journalist.

Active (-ing)

Original: ...who is reading...

The laptop repaired by the technician works ...

Passive (V3)

Original: ...that was repaired...

He is the best athlete ever to have competed...

Infinitive

Original: ...who has ever competed...

The children playing in the garden are my cousins.

Active (-ing)

Original: ...who were playing...

This is the only restaurant to satisfy my taste.

Infinitive

Original: ...that can satisfy...



QUIZ 3 | Find & Fix the Mistake

Each sentence contains ONE mistake. Find it and correct the sentence.

1. The book reading by the students is very long.
2. She is the girl who sleeping in class every day.
3. The car breaking down on the highway was towed away.
4. He is the only student passing that scored 100%.
5. The letters writing by hand felt more personal.

QUIZ 3 | ANSWERS

✗ *reading (should be written)*

'read' is passive → use V3 (written), not -ing.

✓ The book written by the students is very long.

✗ *who sleeping (forgot to remove 'who')*

Remove relative pronoun + BE: 'who is sleeping' → 'sleeping'.

✓ The girl sleeping in class every day.

✗ *breaking (should be broken)*

Passive reduction: 'that broke down' → 'broken down'.

✓ The car broken down on the highway was towed.

✗ *passing (doesn't belong)*

After 'only' use infinitive: 'who scored' → 'to score'.

✓ He is the only student to score 100%.

✗ *writing (should be written)*

Passive: 'which were written' → 'written'.

✓ The letters written by hand felt more personal.



KEY TAKEAWAYS

Reduced Relative Clauses



Active: Remove 'who/which + BE' → keep V-ing



Passive: Remove 'which/that + was/were' → keep V3



Infinitive: After ordinals/modals/superlatives → to + V



Only reduce when relative pronoun = SUBJECT of the clause

Practice makes perfect — keep reducing! 